

Theory and Practice

Review: Dancing Machaut

Article Summary:

A particular group of Machaut's secular songs were self-identified as being for dancing, yet dance choreography and embodiment has not yet been used as a mode for analysis and understanding of this repertory; the author seeks to engage on this level with this repertory to think through how the dancer-singer-composer relationship might have been internalized at the time and how this intimate knowledge of the coordination between choreography, notation, and musical gesture might have permitted Machaut an element of play.

Overall Evaluation: Revise and resubmit

Major Problems & Concerns:

Throughout, I feel like a lot of useful info is buried in the footnotes, where it would be much more helpful to the reader to bolster the argument by including this information in the main body of the text.

Is the carole here being conflated with all songs danced 'in the round' (which includes rondeau) and also with virelai and ductia? Should they all be conflated or do they need to be interpreted and analyzed separately? What is the rationale for grouping them all together here? And is the virelai always a chanson balladée, or can they be distinguished from each other?

I also wonder at the retrospective use of later 16th-century terminology and concepts such as tactus to analyze earlier 13th- and 14th-century musical repertoires – and definitely the usage of French Baroque dance manuals I question. I think they could be worked into the prose in a way that makes clear they are not the main mode of analysis here but rather a support to the author's own observations

Bipedal dance groupings usually corroborate the feeling of binary meter in medieval danced song, that performance practice likely underlying the conventional choice of binary mensuration in the first place. – but surely there are so many examples of danced triple meter, like the waltz – what exactly is meant here by bipedal dance groupings? Even in these triple groupings, the same foot might still get the tonal accent, no?

The author repeatedly states that they are making no claims to medieval practice, but then it isn't entirely clear how the dance steps they suggest are being created, except by noting rhythmic patterns and possible metrical groupings. There might well be multiple possibilities for danced rhythm/pattern for each song, no? And then to claim that certain patterns would have affected dancers, after clarifying that the lead singer-dancer would set the dance steps, doesn't entirely make sense.

I do think the point about notated rests/downbeats is a good one, but it overlooks the simple fact that without the notated rests (and without modern barlines or consistent uses of dots of division,

which wouldn't have occurred in Machaut), the performers would not on first glance know that the work in fact started in the middle of a perfection. Dance, in other words, is not the only reason for the inclusion of these rests.

This study continues modern analytical work on medieval meter by considering mensural levels to be expressed not only by discrete notated rhythms but by free rhythm equivalent to that value. – I don't understand this claim. What is 'free rhythm'?

And there is always the possibility that dancers were not so interested in musical structure and simply marched along to a pretty tune, glad to have the hand of a sweetheart on either side. – doesn't this undercut the entire purpose of this article? I worry that at times throughout, the author inserts asides such as this that really contradict or cast doubt on what they're trying to do here.

Dance steps, virtual or actual, are shown above the score at the modus level for lack of tempus irregularity. – what is meant here by virtual and actual?

The labeling of Ex 14/17 is very confusing – can the grouping labels be separated out from the possible steps?

How would one dance Ex 16/17/18? I get the point about different accents between modus and maximodus, but surely one would not dance maximodus as notated here?

This study does not presume to answer how Machaut's songs were danced, only to grapple with some questions that arise when pairing regular dance steps with irregular musical groupings. – recognizing that this point has been made throughout, I feel it still gets a bit lost in the prose and thus the main argument itself gets lost at times. In other words, the conclusion is good, but I feel that it isn't strongly and clearly built up throughout the article. I think some revision and more careful signposting throughout would be very useful to the reader.

Overall, I think there's value here, but how the author is determining the steps (and only those possibilities for steps) remains vague, and thus the analysis of the intricacies of meter vs mensuration gets muddled. Some restructuring would be great.

Detailed Comments:

Some incomplete sentences, grammar issues throughout; some moments of awkward or unclear prose as well; spell out abbreviations and check hyphenated adjectives. I would also suggest that the author refrain from using dance metaphors to describe musical gestures, out of caution that the reader might think they were suggesting an actual dance step (for ex, a D 'pirouetting' on a neighbor C)

General Advice:

Is Ludwig still the most reliable source for Machaut transcriptions?